based test and marking is objective and accurate with no human bias or errors. Its adoption will not change the admission policy of the university in terms of reservations. It is, of course, mandatory that only CUET score is used for admissions barring in few special disciplines such as theatre, music and sports, in which 15 per cent can be assigned to practical tests or personal interactions.

Although computer-based entrance tests are used the world over, there is no single entrance test that can be called an ideal test. I have so far not seen anyone come up with an alternative method for entrance tests that can accurately

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One advantage with CUET is that it is a computer-based test, and marking is objective and accurate, with little scope for human error

quantify the aptitude, ability and suitability of a student for admission in a discipline. The problem gets more complex when one has to deal with the scale of admission operations that are common in India and which need to be done in a transparent manner. There is no doubt that there is huge public trust in these entrance tests because they are foolproof from the point of influencing the admission outcomes. And entrance tests are also evolving with the introduction of artificial intelligence (AI) and other emerging technologies.

Some critics have argued that students will neglect school education and focus only on CUET. Unless you establish the causal link between CUET and students neglecting board exams, all such arguments are plain conjectures and have no scientific basis. Students who aspire to join IITs usually spend a large part of their time preparing for the JEE. However, more than 98 per cent of the students admitted in IITs do very well in their board exams, a clear indication they have not neglected their school education. Besides, without sound knowledge and understanding—not memorised answers—of what is taught in schools, a student cannot expect to do well in CUET too.

There are nearly 125,000 UG seats in all central universities and even more seats in all the participating universities. Students across India will have an opportunity to compete for these seats. This year, nearly a million students from every state and Union territory of India, from Kashmir to Kanyakumari and Kutch to Kohima, will sit for CUET. Among the southern states, the largest number of students from Kerala followed by Tamil Nadu will be attempting the entrance test. Students from outside India, from places such as Bahrain, Doha, Dubai, Kathmandu, Kuwait, Lagos/ Abuja, Muscat, Riyadh, Sharjah and Singapore, too, have registered for CUET. This will not only help children of Indian diaspora living in these countries but also provide an opportunity to international students to study in Indian universities.

This wide participation of students from across India and the world will increase diversity in our universities, making our campuses more cosmopolitan and vibrant. As a student of IIT Madras, I could meet students from across India and develop lifelong friendships.

Since CUET will be conducted in 12 Indian languages, it will provide greater access to students, irrespective of the medium they studied in at school. Both JEE (Mains) and NEET are conducted in 12 Indian languages. Considering the importance given to Indian languages in the National Education Policy (NEP), even JEE (Advanced) should be in all 12 languages. IITs should take a call on this, as students who come from socio-economically disadvantaged groups are usually more adept in their mother tongue.

I believe CUET should evolve into one single examination for UG admissions in the coming years. The first step could be to use CUET scores for admissions in not only universities but also in engineering and medical institutes by merging CUET, JEE (Mains) and NEET. Agriculture, pharmacy, law and many other universities can join CUET. In addition to the common subjects needed to evaluate an applicant's suitability, CUET can also have additional subject papers to assess the aptitude for a particular discipline. With the possibility that CUET may be conducted twice in a year, it will provide students better opportunities to improve their performance and hence chances of admission.

I have no doubt CUET will emerge as an important reform in higher education in India since Independence. ■

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